

AI-Ready Data: The New Benchmark of Enterprise Competitiveness

Guest: Nick Larson, VP of Technology, Improving

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Guest Context

Nick has been at Improving since 2020, when Object Partners merged in. Before that, 12 years at Object Partners as VP Solution Delivery. Deep technical background (senior developer at Union Pacific, West Corp, MSI) with a long arc toward enterprise solution leadership. He knows the gap between data-in-theory and data-in-practice better than almost anyone. Don't treat him as a talking head — he'll have opinions and will push back if a question is too surface-level.

Episode Theme

The competitive moat is shifting from who has the best AI to who has the best data foundation underneath it. Most enterprises are overestimating their data readiness, underestimating what agentic AI requires, and patching legacy systems with AI layers that will crack. This episode names that problem and gives leaders a framework for thinking about it.

Questions

1. AI Ready Data is almost a buzzword these days, but can you take it beyond that and explain what it actually means?
2. What is the difference between data and models and why has AI-ready data become the competitive advantage?
3. Do you think most enterprises are further behind on data readiness than they think?
4. Talk about why AI outcomes are only as good as the data foundation. If you're putting in garbage data, you're getting garbage results. AI is only as good as the data you give it. It's not a miracle worker.
5. Why do you think it's important for enterprises to shift from data reporting to data for decisioning and automation? Do you think enough enterprises are making this shift?
6. Give our audience a brief reminder about agentic AI and how it raises the stakes. Systems are acting on data rather than just analyzing it.
7. Talk about how the competitive gap is widening between data mature enterprises and data chaotic enterprises. What does this mean for the ones who lean towards the chaotic? What are the long-term effects?

Questions (continued)

8. Lots of enterprises are layering AI on top of legacy data. What happens when this happens? Discuss how piling AI solutions on top of one another is a band-aid solution that will break.
9. Agentic AI is changing the game a lot. How is it changing the requirements for data quality and structure?
10. With all this talk about good data, can you talk about what that actually looks like? How do I know that my data is trustworthy when my AI agents are making decisions? Talk about strong metadata, lineage, and observability. Talk about clear ownership. Talk about embedded governance. Talk about some of the most overlooked components of AI-ready data. How do you know when your data is ready?
11. How does data readiness impact the risk of autonomous systems making the wrong call?
12. Look into your crystal ball. In 2-3 years, what will separate companies that experiment with AI from those that become AI-driven?
13. What are your key takeaways from today's conversation?

Closing

Thank Nick, tease next episode, remind listeners to subscribe and share.